

'That is well, sire: for I have my affairs to settle before I set out; particularly if it is likely there should be any blows stirring.'

'That may happen.'

'We can receive them! But, sire, you have addressed yourself to avarice, to ambition; you have addressed yourself to the heart of M. d'Aragnan, but you have forgotten one thing.'

'What is that?'

'You have said nothing to his vanity; when shall I be a knight of the king's orders?'

'Does that interest you?'

'Why, yes, sire. My friend Athos is quite covered with orders, and that dazzles me.'

'You shall be a knight of my order a month after you have taken your commission of captain.'

'Ah! ah!' said the officer, thoughtfully, 'after the expedition.'

'Precisely.'

'Where is your majesty going to send me?'

'Are you acquainted with Bretagne?'

'No, sire.'

'Have you any friends there?'

'In Bretagne? No, *ma foi*!'

'So much the better. Do you know anything about fortifications?'

'I believe I do, sire,' said D'Aragnan, smiling.

'That is to say you can readily distinguish a fortress from a simple fortification, such as is allowed to châtelains or vassals?'

'I distinguish a fort from a rampart as I distinguish a cuirass from a raised pie-crust, sire. Is that sufficient?'

'Yes, monsieur. You will set out, then.'

'For Bretagne?'

'Yes.'

'Alone?'

'Absolutely alone. That is to say, you must not even take a lackey with you. May I ask your majesty for what reason?'

'Because, monsieur, it will be necessary to disguise yourself sometimes, as the servant of a good family. Your face is very well known in France, M. d'Aragnan.'

'And then, sire?'

'And then you will travel slowly through Bretagne, and will examine the fortifications of that country.'

'The coasts?'

'Yes, and the isles; commencing by Belle-Ile-en-Mer.'

'Ah! which belongs to M. Fouquet?' said D'Aragnan, in a serious tone, raising his intelligent eye to Louis XIV.

'I fancy you are right, monsieur, and that Belle-Isle does belong to M. Fouquet, in fact.'

'Then your majesty wishes me to ascertain if Belle-Isle is a strong place?'

'Yes.'

'If the fortifications of it are new or old?'

'Precisely.'

'And if the vassals of M. Fouquet are sufficiently numerous to form a garrison?'

'That is what I want to know; you have placed your finger on the question.'

'And if they are not fortifying, sire?'

'You will travel about Bretagne, listening and judging.'

'Then I am a king's spy?' said D'Aragnan, bluntly, twisting his moustache.

'No, monsieur.'

'Your pardon sire; I spy on your majesty's account.'

'You start on a voyage of discovery, monsieur. Would you march at the head of your musketeers, with your sword in your hand, to observe any spot whatever, or an enemy's position?'

At this word D'Aragnan started.

'Do you,' continued the king, 'imagine yourself to be a spy?'

'No, no,' said D'Aragnan, but pensively; 'the thing changes its face when one observes an enemy: one is but a soldier. And if they are fortifying Belle-Isle?' added he, quickly.

'You will take an exact plan of the fortifications.'

'Will they permit me to enter?'

'That does not concern me; that is your affair. Did you not understand that I reserved for you a supplement of twenty thousand livres per annum, if you wished it?'

'Yes, sire; but if they are not fortifying?'

'You will return quietly, without fatiguing your horse.'

'Sire, I am ready.'

'You will begin to-morrow by going to monsieur le surintendant's to take the first quarter of the pension I give you. Do you know M. Fouquet?'

'Very little, sire; but I beg your majesty to observe that I don't think it immediately necessary that I should know him.'

'Your pardon, monsieur; for he will refuse you the money I wish you to take; and it is that refusal I look for.'

'Ah!' said D'Artagnan. 'Then, sire?'

'The money being refused, you will go and seek it at M. Colbert's. À propos, have you a good horse?'

'An excellent one, sire.'

'How much did it cost you?'

'A hundred and fifty pistoles.'

'I will buy it of you. Here is a note for two hundred pistoles.'

'But I want a horse for my journey, sire.'

'Well!'

'Well, and you take mine from me.'

'Not at all. On the contrary, I give it you. Only as it is now mine and not yours, I am sure you will not spare it.'

'Your majesty is in a hurry, then?'

'A great hurry.'

'Then what compels me to wait two days?'

'Reasons known to myself.'

'That's a different affair. The horse may make up the two days, in the eight he has to travel; and then there is the post.'

'No, no, the post compromises, Monsieur d'Artagnan. Begone and do not forget you are my servant.'

'Sire, it is not my duty to forget it! At what hour to-morrow shall I take my leave of your majesty?'

'Whence do you lodge?'

still hesitated, and hung down his head. 'Come, monsieur,' said the king, 'one would believe, to look at you, that you did not know that at the court of the most Christian king, the captain-general of the musketeers takes precedence of the *maréchals* of France.'

'Sire, I know he does.'

'Then, am I to think you do put no faith in my word?'

'Oh! sire, never—never dream of such a thing.'

'I have wished to prove to you, that you, so good a servant, had lost a good master; am I anything like the master that will suit you?'

'I begin to think you are, sire.'

'Then, monsieur, you will resume your functions. Your company is quite disorganized since your departure, and the men go about drinking and rioting in the cabarets, where they fight, in spite of my edicts, and those of my father. You will reorganize the service as soon as possible.'

'Yes, sire.'

'You will not again quit my person.'

'Very well, sire.'

'You will march with me to the army, you will encamp round my tent.'

'Then, sire,' said D'Artagnan, 'if it is only to impose upon me a service like that, your majesty need not give me twenty thousand livres a year. I shall not earn them.'

'I desire that you shall keep open house; I desire that you should keep a liberal table; I desire that my captain of musketeers should be a personage.'

'And I,' said D'Artagnan, bluntly; 'I do not like easily found money; I like money won! Your majesty gives me an idle trade, which the first comer would perform for four thousand livres.'

Louis XIV began to laugh. 'You are a true Gascon, Monsieur d'Artagnan; you will draw my heart's secret from me.'

'Bah! has your majesty a secret, then?'

'Yes, monsieur.'

'Well! then I accept the twenty thousand livres, for I will keep that secret, and discretion is above all price, in these times. Will your majesty speak now?'

'Boot yourself, Monsieur d'Artagnan, and to horse!'

'Directly, sire.'

'Within two days.'

after these three steps, stopping, passing, and coming back to the musketeer,—‘Now, monsieur,’ said he, ‘let us hasten to terminate our affair. You told me the other day, at Blois, that you were not rich?’

‘But I am now, sire.’

‘Yes, but that does not concern me; you have your own money, not mine; that does not enter into my account.’

‘I do not well understand what your majesty means.’

‘Then, instead of leaving you to draw out words, speak spontaneously. Should you be satisfied with twenty thousand livres a year as a fixed income?’

‘But, sire,’ said D’Artagnan, opening his eyes to the utmost.

‘Would you be satisfied with four horses furnished and kept, and with a supplement of funds such as you might require, according to occasions and needs, or would you prefer a fixed sum which would be, for example, forty thousand livres? Answer.’

‘Sire, your majesty—’

‘Yes, you are surprised; that is natural, and I expected it. Answer me, come! or I shall think you have no longer that rapidity of judgment I have so much admired in you.’

‘It is certain, sire, that twenty thousand livres a year make a handsome sum; but—’

‘No buts! Yes or no, is it an honourable indemnity?’

‘Oh! very certainly.’

‘You will be satisfied with it? That is well. It will be better to reckon the extra expenses separately; you can arrange that with Colbert. Now let us pass to something more important.’

‘But, sire, I told your majesty—’

‘That you wanted rest, I know you did: only I replied that I would not allow it—I am master, I suppose?’

‘Yes, sire.’

‘That is well. You were formerly in the way of becoming captain of the musketeers?’

‘Yes, sire.’

‘Well, here is your commission signed. I place it in this drawer. The day on which you return from a certain expedition which I have to confide to you, on that day you may yourself take the commission from the drawer.’ D’Artagnan

‘I must henceforward lodge at the Louvre.’

‘That must not be now—keep your lodgings in the city: I will pay for them. As to your departure, it must take place at night; you must set out without being seen by any one, or, if you are seen, it must not be known that you belong to me. Keep your mouth shut, monsieur.’

‘Your majesty spoils all you have said by that single word.’

‘I asked where you lodged, for I cannot always send to M. le Comte de la Fère to seek you.’

‘I lodge with M. Planchet, a grocer, Rue des Lombards, at the sign of the “Pilon d’Or.”’

‘Go out but little, show yourself less, and await my orders.’

‘And yet, sire, I must go for the money.’

‘That is true, but when going to the superintendence, where so many people are constantly going, you must mingle with the crowd.’

‘I want the notes, sire, for the money.’

‘Here they are.’ The king signed them, and D’Artagnan looked on, to assure himself of their regularity.

‘Adieu! Monsieur d’Artagnan,’ added the king; ‘I think you have perfectly understood me.’

‘I? I understand that your majesty sends me to Belle-Île-en-Mer, that is all.’

‘To learn?’

‘To learn how M. Fouquet’s works are going on; that is all.’

‘Very well: I admit you may be taken.’

‘And I do not admit it,’ replied the Gascon, boldly.

‘I admit you may be killed,’ continued the king.

‘That is not probable, sire.’

‘In the first case, you must not speak; in the second there must be no papers found upon you.’

D’Artagnan shrugged his shoulders without ceremony, and took leave of the king, saying to himself:—‘The English shower continues—let us remain under the spout!’

forgot to announce to your majesty,' said he, 'that the confiscations amount to the sum of five millions of livres.'

'That's pretty well!' thought D'Arragnan.

'Which makes in my coffers?' said the king.

'Eighteen millions of livres, sire,' replied Colbert, bowing.

'*Mordoux!*' growled D'Arragnan, 'that's glorious!'

'Monsieur Colbert,' added the king, 'you will, if you please, go through the gallery where M. Lyonne is waiting, and will tell him to bring hither what he has drawn up—by my order.'

'Directly, sire; if your majesty wants me no more this evening?'

'No, monsieur: good-night!' And Colbert went out.

'Now, let us return to our affair, M. d'Arragnan,' said the king, as if nothing had happened. 'You see that, with respect to money, there is already a notable change.'

'Something to the tune of from zero to eighteen millions,' replied the musketeer gayly. 'Ah! that was what your majesty wanted the day King Charles II came to Blois. The two states would not have been embroiled to-day; for I must say, that there also I see another stumbling-block.'

'Well, in the first place,' replied Louis, 'you are unjust, monsieur; for, if Providence had made me able to give my brother the million that day, you would not have quitted my service, and, consequently, you would not have made your fortune, as you told me just now you have done. But, in addition to this, I have had another piece of good fortune; and my difference with Great Britain need not alarm you.'

A valet de chambre interrupted the king by announcing M. Lyonne. 'Come in, monsieur,' said the king; 'you are punctual; that is like a good servant. Let us see your letter to my brother Charles II.'

D'Arragnan pricked up his ears. 'A moment, monsieur,' said Louis carelessly to the Gascon; 'I must expedite to London my consent to the marriage of my brother, M. le Duc d'Anjou, with the Princess Henrietta Stuart.'

'He is knocking me about, it seems,' murmured D'Arragnan, whilst the king signed the letter, and dismissed M. de Lyonne; 'but *ma foi!* the more he knocks me about in this manner, the better I like it.'

The king followed M. de Lyonne with his eyes, till the door was closed behind him; he even made three steps, as if he would follow the minister; but,

These two men looked at each other—D'Artagnan, with eyes open and bright as the day—Colbert, with his half closed, and dim. The frank intrepidity of the financier annoyed the other; the circumsppection of the financier disgusted the soldier. 'Ah! ah! this is the gentleman who made that brilliant stroke in England,' said Colbert. And he bowed slightly to D'Artagnan.

'Ah! ah!' said the Gascon, 'this is the gentleman who clipped off the lace from the uniform of the Swiss! A praiseworthy piece of economy.'

The financier thought to pierce the musketeer; but the musketeer ran the financier through.

'Monsieur d'Artagnan,' resumed the king, who had not remarked all the shades of which Mazarin would have missed not one, 'this concerns the farmers of the revenue who have robbed me, whom I am hanging, and whose death-warrants I am about to sign.'

'Oh! oh!' said D'Artagnan, starting.

'What did you say?'

'Oh! nothing, sire. This is no business of mine.'

The king had already taken up the pen, and was applying it to the paper. 'Sire,' said Colbert in a subdued voice, 'I beg to warn your majesty, that if an example be necessary, there will be difficulty in the execution of your orders.'

'What do you say?' said Louis.

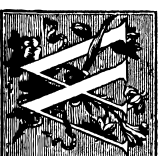
'You must not conceal from yourself,' continued Colbert quietly, 'that attacking the farmers-general is attacking the superintendence. The two unfortunate guilty men in question are the particular friends of a powerful personage, and the punishment, which otherwise might be comfortably confined to the Châtelet, will doubtless be a signal for disturbances!'

Louis coloured and turned towards D'Artagnan, who took a slight bite at his moustache, not without a smile of pity for the financier, and for the king who had to listen to him so long. But Louis seized the pen, and with a movement so rapid that his hand shook, he affixed his signature at the bottom of the two papers presented by Colbert,—then looking the latter in the face,—'Monsieur Colbert,' said he, 'when you speak to me on business, exclude more frequently the word difficulty from your reasonings and opinions; as to the word impossibility, never pronounce it.'

Colbert bowed, much humiliated at having to undergo such a lesson before the musketeer; he was about to go out, but, jealous to repair his check: 'I

Chapter LIV

The Houses of M. Fouquet



MUST D'Artagnan was returning to Planchet's house, his head aching and bewildered with all that had happened to him, there was passing a scene of quite a different character, and which, nevertheless, is not foreign to the conversation our musketeer had just had with the king: only this scene took place out of Paris, in a house possessed by the superintendent Fouquet in the village of Saint-Mande. The minister had just arrived at this country-house, followed by his principal clerk, who carried an enormous portfolio full of papers to be examined, and others waiting for signature. As it might be about five o'clock in the afternoon, the masters had dined: supper was being prepared for twenty subaltern guests. The superintendent did not stop: on alighting from his carriage, he, at the same bound, sprang through the doorway, traversed the apartments and gained his cabinet, where he declared he would shut himself up to work, commanding that he should not be disturbed for anything but an order from the king. As soon as this order was given, Fouquet shut himself up, and two footmen were placed as sentinels at his door. Then Fouquet pushed a bolt which displaced a panel that walled up the entrance, and prevented everything that passed in this apartment from being either seen or heard. But, against all probability, it was only for the sake of shutting himself up that Fouquet shut himself up thus, for he went straight to a bureau, seated himself at it, opened the portfolio, and began to make a choice amongst the enormous mass of papers it contained. It was not more than ten minutes after he had entered, and taken all the precautions we have described, when the repeated noise of several slight equal knocks struck his ear, and appeared to fix his utmost attention. Fouquet raised his head, turned his ear, and listened.

The strokes continued. Then the worker arose with a slight movement of impatience and walked straight up to a glass behind which the blows were struck by a hand, or by some invisible mechanism. It was a large glass let into a panel. Three other glasses, exactly similar to it, completed the symmetry of the apartment. Nothing distinguished that one from the others. Without doubt, these reiterated knocks were a signal; for, at the moment Fouquet approached the glass listening, the same noise was renewed, and in the same measure. 'Oh! oh!' murmured the intendant, with surprise, 'who is yonder? I did not expect anybody to-day.' And without doubt, to respond to the signal, he pulled out a gilded nail near the glass, and shook it thrice. Then returning to his place, and seating himself again, '*Ma foi!* let them wait,' said he. And plunging again into the ocean of papers unrolled before him, he appeared to think of nothing now but work. In fact, with incredible rapidity and marvellous lucidity, Fouquet deciphered the largest papers and most complicated writings, correcting them, annotating them with a pen moved as if by a fever, and the work melting under his hands, signatures, figures, references, became multiplied as if ten clerks—that is to say, a hundred fingers and ten brains had performed the duties, instead of the five fingers and single brain of this man. From time to time, only, Fouquet, absorbed by his work, raised his head to cast a furtive glance upon a clock placed before him. The reason of this was, Fouquet set himself a task, and when this task was once set, in one hour's work he, by himself, did what another would not have accomplished in a day; always certain, consequently, provided he was not disturbed, of arriving at the close in the time his devouring activity had fixed. But in the midst of his ardent labour, the soft strokes upon the little bell placed behind the glass sounded again, hasty, and, consequently, more urgent.

'The lady appears to be impatient,' said Fouquet. 'Humph! a calm! That must be the comtesse; but, no, the comtesse is gone to Rambouillet for three days. The presidente, then? Oh! no, the presidente would not assume such grand airs; she would ring very humbly, then she would wait my good pleasure. The greatest certainty is, that I do not know who it can be, but that I know who it cannot be. And since it is not you, marquise, since it cannot be you, deuce take the rest! And he went on with his work in spite of the reiterated appeals of the bell. At the end of a quarter of an hour, however, impatience prevailed over Fouquet in his turn: he might be said to consume, rather than

'I formed that resolution when I was poor and destitute.'
'So be it. Go on.'

'Now, when by my energy I have acquired a comfortable means of subsistence, would your majesty despoil me of my liberty? Your majesty would condemn me to the lowest, when I have gained the highest?'

'Who gave you permission, monsieur, to fathom my designs, or to reckon with me?' replied Louis, in a voice almost angry; 'who told you what I shall do or what you will yourself do?'

'Sire,' said the musketeer, quietly, 'as far as I see, freedom is not the order of the conversation, as it was on the day we came to an explanation at Blois.'

'No, monsieur; everything is changed.'

'I tender your majesty my sincere compliments upon that, but—'

'But you don't believe it?'

'I am not a great statesman, and yet I have my eye upon affairs; it seldom fails; now, I do not see exactly as your majesty does, sire. The reign of Mazarin is over, but that of the financiers is begun. They have the money; your majesty will not often see much of it. To live under the paw of these hungry wolves is hard for a man who reckoned upon independence.'

At this moment someone scratched at the door of the cabinet; the king raised his head proudly. 'Your pardon, Monsieur d'Artagnan,' said he; 'it is M. Colbert, who comes to make me a report. Come in, M. Colbert.'

D'Artagnan drew back. Colbert entered with papers in his hand, and went up to the king. There can be little doubt that the Gascon did not lose the opportunity of applying his keen, quick glance to the new figure which presented itself.

'Is the inquiry made?'

'Yes, sire.'

'And the opinion of the inquisitors?'

'Is that the accused merit confiscation and death?'

'Ah! ah!' said the king, without changing countenance, and casting an oblique look at D'Artagnan. 'And your own opinion, M. Colbert?' said he. Colbert looked at D'Artagnan is his turn. That imposing countenance checked the words upon his lips. Louis perceived this. 'Do not disturb yourself,' said he; 'it is M. d'Artagnan,—do you not know M. d'Artagnan again?'

‘Then give me quickly one solution. My time is valuable. What have you been doing since your discharge?’

‘Making my fortune, sire.’

‘The expression is crude, Monsieur d’Aragnan.’

‘Your majesty takes it in bad part, certainly. I entertain nothing but the profoundest respect for the king; and if I have been impolite, which might be excused by my long sojourn in camps and barracks, your majesty is too much above me to be offended at a word that innocently escapes from a soldier.’

‘In fact, I know you performed a brilliant action in England, monsieur. I only regret that you have broken your promise.’

‘I!’ cried D’Aragnan.

‘Doubtless. You engaged your word not to serve any other prince on quitting my service. Now it was for King Charles II that you undertook the marvellous carrying off of M. Monk.’

‘Pardon me, sire; it was for myself.’

‘And did you succeed?’

‘Like the captains of the fifteenth century, coups-de-main and adventures.’

‘What do you call succeeding?—a fortune?’

‘A hundred thousand crowns, sire, which I now possess—that is, in one week three times as much money as I ever had in fifty years.’

‘It is a handsome sum. But you are ambitious, I perceive.’

‘I, sire? The quarter of that would be a treasure; and I swear to you I have no thought of augmenting it.’

‘What! you contemplate remaining idle?’

‘Yes, sire.’

‘You mean to drop the sword?’

‘That I have already done.’

‘Impossible, Monsieur d’Aragnan,’ said Louis, firmly.

‘But, sire—’

‘Well?’

‘And why, sire?’

‘Because it is my wish you should not!’ said the young prince, in a voice so stern and imperious that D’Aragnan evinced surprise and even uneasiness.

‘Will your majesty allow me one word of reply?’ said he.

‘Speak.’

to complete the rest of his work; he thrust his papers into his portfolio, and giving a glance at the mirror, whilst the taps continued faster than ever: ‘Oh! oh!’ said he, ‘whence comes all this racket? What has happened, and who can the Ariadne be who expects me so impatiently. Let us see!’

He then applied the tip of his finger to the nail parallel to the one he had drawn. Immediately the glass moved like a folding-door and discovered a secret closet, rather deep, into which the superintendent disappeared as if going into a vast box. When there, he touched another spring, which opened, not a board, but a block of the wall, and he went out by that opening, leaving the door to shut of itself. Then Fouquet descended about a score of steps which sank, winding, underground, and came to a long, subterranean passage, lighted by imperceptible loopholes. The walls of this vault were covered with slabs or tiles, and the floor with carpeting. This passage was under the street itself, which separated Fouquet’s house from the Park of Vincennes. At the end of the passage ascended a winding staircase parallel with that by which Fouquet had entered. He mounted these other stairs, entered by means of a spring placed in a closet similar to that in his cabinet, and from this closet an untenanted chamber furnished with the utmost elegance. As soon as he entered, he examined carefully whether the glass closed without leaving any trace, and, doubtless satisfied with his observation, he opened by means of a small gold key the triple fastenings of a door in front of him. This time the door opened upon a handsome cabinet, sumptuously furnished, in which was seated upon cushions a lady of surpassing beauty, who at the sound of the lock sprang towards Fouquet. ‘Ah! good heavens!’ cried the latter, starting back with astonishment. ‘Madame la Marquise de Bellière, you here?’

‘Yes,’ murmured la marquise. ‘Yes, it is I, monsieur.’

‘Marquise! dear marquise!’ added Fouquet, ready to prostrate himself. ‘Ah! my God! how did you come here? And I, to keep you waiting!’

‘A long time, monsieur; yes, a very long time!’

‘I am happy in thinking this waiting has appeared long to you, marquise!’

‘Oh! an eternity, monsieur; oh! I rang more than twenty times. Did you not hear me?’

‘Marquise, you are pale, you tremble.’

‘Did you not hear, then, that you were summoned?’

'Oh, yes; I heard plainly enough, madame; but I could not come. After your rigours and your refusals, how could I dream it was you? If I could have had any suspicion of the happiness that awaited me, believe me, madame, I would have quitted everything to fall at your feet, as I do at this moment.'

'Are we quite alone, monsieur?' asked the marquise, looking round the room.

'Oh, yes, madame, I can assure you of that.'

'Really?' said the marquise, in a melancholy tone.

'You sigh!' said Fouquet.

'What mysteries! what precautions!' said the marquise, with a slight bitterness of expression; 'and how evident it is that you fear the least suspicion of your amours to escape.'

'Would you prefer their being made public?'

'Oh, no, you act like a delicate man,' said the marquise, smiling.

'Come, dear marquise, punish me not with reproaches, I implore you.'

'Reproaches! Have I a right to make you any?'

'No, unfortunately, no; but tell me, you, who during a year I have loved without return or hope—'

'You are mistaken—without hope it is true, but not without return.'

'What! for me, of my love! there is but one proof, and that proof I still want.'

'I am here to bring it, monsieur.'

Fouquet wished to clasp her in his arms, but she disengaged herself with a gesture.

'You persist in deceiving yourself, monsieur, and will never accept of me the only thing I am willing to give you—devotion.'

'Ah, then, you do not love me? Devotion is but a virtue, love is a passion.'

'Listen to me, I implore you: I should not have come hither without a serious motive: you are well assured of that, are you not?'

'The motive is of very little consequence, so that you are but here—so that I see you—so that I speak to you!'

'You are right; the principal thing is that I am here without any one having seen me, and that I can speak to you.'—Fouquet sank on his knees before her. 'Speak! speak, madame!' said he, 'I listen to you.'

bone would be thrown to me. I, although poor likewise, asked nothing of your majesty but the discharge you speak of.'

'I know you are a brave man, but I was a young man, and you ought to have had some indulgence for me. What had you to reproach the king with?—that he left King Charles II without assistance?—let us say further—that he did not marry Mademoiselle de Mancini? When saying these words, the king fixed upon the musketeer a searching look.

'Ah! ah!' thought the latter, 'he is doing far more than remembering, he divines. The devil!'

'Your sentence,' continued Louis, 'fell upon the king and fell upon the man. But, Monsieur d'Arragnan, that weakness, for you considered it a weakness?—D'Arragnan made no reply—'you reproached me also with regard to monsieur, the defunct cardinal. Now, monsieur le cardinal, did he not bring me up, did he not support me?—elevating himself and supporting himself at the same time, I admit; but the benefit was discharged. As an ingrate or an egotist, would you, then, have better loved or served me?'

'Sire!'

'We will say no more about it, monsieur; it would only create in you too many regrets, and me too much pain.'

D'Arragnan was not convinced. The young king, in adopting a tone of hauteur with him, did not forward his purpose.

'You have since reflected?' resumed Louis.

'Upon what, sire?' asked D'Arragnan, politely.

'Why, upon all that I have said to you, monsieur.'

'Yes, sire, no doubt—'

'And you have only waited for an opportunity of retracting your words?'

'Sire!'

'You hesitate, it seems.'

'I do not understand what your majesty did me the honour to say to me.' Louis's brow became cloudy.

'Have the goodness to excuse me, sire; my understanding is particularly thick; things do not penetrate it without difficulty; but it is true, once they get in, they remain there.'

'Yes, yes, you appear to have a memory.'

'Almost as good a one as your majesty's.'